

The Asteroid

1. The Asteroid

Marek stood watching his datapad, his mind drifting back through the years—thinking of all those tiny bits of information his young mind used to devour so eagerly. As a child, he had stared in awe at the rocket pilots, scientists, explorers, and technicians. They were out there exploring, expanding; back then, it all seemed so simple. I will grow up one day, and I will discover my own stars. I'll colonize, develop, construct from scratch. It was that simple: just try hard, keep your head up, and eventually opportunity would land at your feet. You would prove yourself, show valor, and earn respect. A simple pipeline of justice. What could possibly go wrong?

Over time, he learned that actually, everything could—and indeed does—go wrong.

The Asteroid Belt in 2700 was built on a grand myth: the frontier of endless opportunity, a roaring frontier of hope, big corporate games, and booming human expansion. But underneath the glittering propaganda, it was a place of endless, petty squabbles—a system where the privileged few hoarded everything, leaving barely a scrap for anyone else.

It took Marek a long time to understand why it was that way, but deep down he finally got it: there simply wasn't enough opportunity for everybody. The system was mechanically, fundamentally unjust. For him, it was supposedly a "health issue"; for someone else, "education"—there was always some convenient justification to lock you out. If they had explicitly stated from the get-go, 'We are the wealthy elite and you can simply kiss our ass,' at least it would have been honest. Instead, he was blatantly sold propaganda on every corner about how great he could become—yet barely anybody actually made anything of themselves. Weird, isn't it? But the system always turned it back on you: You haven't tried enough. You weren't solid enough. Start with simple things and progress from the bottom, prove yourself. Absolute nonsense. By the time you proved yourself, you were sixty. Honesty is all we wanted—maybe then I would have navigated differently.

Marek lived in a tiny, hollowed-out rock called Rivet-38. Centuries ago, when the first drill rigs cracked its crust, planners envisioned the colony as a self-sustaining haven in the dark. It was supposed to be a haven; instead, nothing had changed over the centuries—if anything, it had gotten even worse. Marek had never looked at it that way. To him, it was just a tiny tin prison for his ambition, defying all those grand premises, sitting a few kilometers from an actual spaceport, yet seemingly stranded forever.

At forty-six, he knew every corridor, rusted bulkhead, and cold rock wall on the station just a little too well.

The worst part about proving yourself to society and the system was that even if you wanted to—which Marek wasn't interested in in the slightest—there wasn't a whole lot you could actually do. His life was defined by an unbearable, everlasting routine: endless stretches of forced "leisure" time interrupted by just a sliver of actual work. Day after day, he watched time bleed away without leaving a trace, his youth and potential evaporating into the recirculated air, no matter how much he wished otherwise.

So this was it. They sold you a lie of greatness, forced you to comply to prove your worth, and yet they knew that as people age, they conform. They erode. A petty local gathering or neighborhood gossip eventually becomes your high-stakes game. They just keep you around as a spare resource they will never actually tap. Could you imagine it ending that way? Marek struggled with that realization every single day.

Sometimes he asked himself how the station—how the whole damn Belt—even functioned. Other people somehow managed to piece a life together out of the grey routines, but Marek lived strictly by the day, constantly waiting for real life to kick in. There was a time when he had begun to accept the bitter truth that it probably never would, but he never fully caved in. He was an optimist at heart, a die-hard despite everything. But still, it was bad. Bouncing from one dead-end berth to another across the sector could scarcely be called living. Some people had families, which was fair enough, but even those without managed to find small joys, simple satisfactions to anchor themselves. Marek had neither.

To him, it was so simple—maybe he was the simplest of them all, and maybe that was why he had always been ridiculed as a dreamer. But it was what it was: the cosmos resonated deep within him, and yet his ambition was way out of reach. Marek was completely obsessed with deep-space flight. As a child, he could recognize almost any ship approaching the spaceport from far out in the dark. He used to pretend he was actually piloting one—shouting orders, drawing flight trajectories, and tapping imaginary buttons.

Eventually, imagination wasn't enough. He applied, just as many of his peers did, and like so many others, he was rejected on the spot. That was essentially the end of the story—and the story is almost always the same—because bad health and zero connections had shut the door on him for good. High-born corporate kids bought clean medical records; Marek just got a permanent rejection.

For years, he held onto a dream the rest of the station had deemed impossible, trapped in a hollow, withering loop of watching a world he wasn't allowed to join. What grew over time was a deep, festering resentment toward petty corporate politics and the mundane reality of his daily rituals—running around the station, pretending he actually cared. Yes, as a boy, he had cared, oblivious to reality, but he had grown sour over time. Still, even with that restlessness inside him, he found peace in looking at the stars, dreaming, or just staring up into the void. Man, they are so fucking mine, he thought to himself.

By law—specifically the Inter-System Labor Preservation Act passed two centuries ago—corporations could not run 100% automated operations. Even though heavy industrial "Scotty" units and third-generation autonomous dredges handled most of the actual extraction, mining conglomerates were legally forced to maintain a 25% human labor quota.

In practice, this meant Marek spent twelve hours every fourth day sitting in a tiny glass-walled booth above a churning pit of molten iron. Every eleven minutes, a terminal would chime, presenting him with a blue diagnostic screen. His job was to look at a sensor readout, compare two numbers generated by a machine, and tap a green icon to confirm the machine hadn't lied to itself. It was soul-crushing work designed purely to satisfy a tax credit. "So this is proving yourself, you slick motherfuckers? Didn't I prove already that I can hit this fucking green square every single time?"

Despite his age, Marek remained restless, impatient, and constantly dissatisfied. He wasn't a bad guy—he didn't start fights in the galley, and he nodded politely in the corridors—but people kept their distance.

In a place like Rivet-38, you had to prove to others that you were equally engaged, that you were serious about the life and survival of the colony. On paper, it sounded simple enough: just participate in the community, take the small things seriously, and buy into the shared routine. But for Marek, even that basic standard was completely out of reach.

And his rants about the cosmos were simply childish to the people around him. He ranted a lot about many things—criticizing mostly the injustices of the system—and while others had coped decades ago, he couldn't, because despite everything, he still dreamed big. Resentful or not, he was sure of one thing: he would show them all in due time. But this mindset often led to agonizing alienation. He felt in his gut that others saw right through his frustration to the base reality: he had been rejected

early, like many others; they had coped and moved on, but he had stayed in the same place. Yet he knew if he were to just "cope" or "move on," it would be the absolute end of his dreams. Moreover, deep down, he knew he would fail to comply anyway—he was too fragile, too sensitive to brutally cut away his past.

Meanwhile, the reality of his depleted time weighed on him constantly. His restless mind served as a perpetual reminder that his personal clock was ticking—it always had been—and he had done next to nothing with the years he'd been given. It wasn't that he didn't want to. He simply didn't fit. On an asteroid station, you either accepted your humble place in the collective or you rotted. You had to find something to be good at to thrive, but Marek was only good at three things: dreaming, complaining, and being frustrated by everyone around him.

Years ago, in his twenties, he had tried to chase "color" in cheap alcohol and petty station parties, but he had long outgrown that slacker lifestyle. Now he just lived in limbo. He couldn't bring himself to accept his current misery, yet he couldn't figure out any real path to a future.

And yet, he still went to the library once in a while, hooked on educational content. If given the chance, he would look at the stars through the instruments, lying flat all night just staring up at the sky through the viewports. On those days, he was completely detached from reality—until reality snapped him back like a slingshot. It was always like this: ten, twenty, thirty, forty years passing by, just another day watching and dreaming, until he finally told himself, "I need to take care of mundane stuff now." After all, he had been rejected—so what else could he possibly do?

He had spent his youth watching younger recruits—often corporate-sponsored kids with pristine medical records—fly the heavy ore haulers out to Europa and Titan. It didn't even matter that his minor ventricular murmur and slight lung scarring from early-life scrubber failures didn't actually affect his ability to fly; corporate methodologies and rigid bureaucratic processes demanded absolute perfection on paper—a convenient filter to disqualify anyone without elite backing. He watched his twenties and thirties evaporate into thin air, leaving behind nothing but a quiet, burning bitterness over every opportunity he'd been denied. The injustice of it ate at him: privileged kids handed actual lives, while guys like him were left waiting for a "someday" that never came.

And yet, the supreme irony was that he was in space. He was floating in the actual Asteroid Belt. Beneath the resentment, Marek was still endlessly curious. He possessed a genuine, aching hunger to know the cosmos, to see past the next ridge, to

witness the vastness beyond the lead-glass ports. It devastated him that he was completely alone in that feeling—that the people around him viewed him as a foolish dreamer who couldn't be serious for a single minute. Real adventure, starships, and the deep dark were always just around the corner, yet perpetually out of reach.

And yet, he was never fully desperate; he was just patient in his own way. Others had dismissed him long ago—unengaged, unreliable, a perpetual job hopper. He did the bare minimum when forced to, but that was all. People like him always lingered in the background—semi-pariahs, never explicitly cast out, but never truly accepted. Still, he clung to his ridiculous fantasies of adventure. And now, an opening had appeared—a rule everyone knew about, though nobody expected someone his age to take it seriously.

On his 46th birthday, the system finally shifted.

Under space law, Article 45 was an unwritten pact between the corps and older Belters: reach forty-five, and medical restrictions no longer applied. The logic wasn't merciful—it was strictly economic. At forty-five, long-term health liabilities spiked anyway, so the fleet waived health disqualifications for high-risk, low-tier berths. If an old clerk with bad lungs wanted to risk dying in a vacuum, it saved the station a pension payout.

But Marek suspected there was something deeper at play—a quiet mechanism for social cohesion. When he was younger, he clung to the hope that he would eventually find his place in this small universe, one way or another. He never did, and he learned firsthand how bitter that failure tasted. You simply start sliding into limbo. Article 45 was the system's way of sweeping people like him out of the public space, offering restless souls a convenient escape route. Usually, that escape was just an illusion, a phantom fresh start. But even a shadow of hope is enough to keep a desperate man hooked.

Over the years, Marek had seen plenty of misfits vanish into deep space, never to return. Some left by their own free will; many others were given a quiet shove by station management. While barely anyone actually looked forward to reaching that grim milestone, Marek was different. He had been waiting for it.

For guys like him, this was the only real chance left. Living on a rock with zero stakes had become maddening, the only things that actually contributed to his life were those relatively rare library escapades that drove him to spend his off-hours studying technical fields. But without context or a real job, he kept losing focus, watching the years slip away.

And yet, he was forty-six Then the notification came through: the system had flagged him as eligible.

It was a strange feeling. He had spent years awaiting this exact moment, but when it actually arrived, a creeping lack of energy and a quiet, nervous uneasiness made him hesitate.

Yet things felt distinctly different this time. Looking up at the assignment board, it was no longer a pure abstraction. Was he too old? Sure. Was he unfit? Sure as hell. But he was legal, and more importantly, he had nothing left to lose on this rock. This was no longer just a theoretical exercise. In the days leading up to his birthday, he had kept a close eye on the board, and then—boom—the status flag flipped to green. For the first time in forty-six years, he was actually somebody. At least on paper.

He stood before the console and reviewed the options laid out before him. There were no high-tier berths or prestige assignments—just the usual low-grade listings he had watched other men browse his entire life. But now, it was worth looking at them through new eyes: as someone who finally counted.

- AUXILIARY SERVICEMAN | Unmapped Belt Relay Long-range array monitoring & uncrewed relay checks.
- AUXILIARY SERVICEMAN | Venus Cloud Buoy Platform status checks under high-ambient pressure.
- DEBRIS PILOT | Ceres Graveyard Shift Manual scrap-tug ops clearing heavy orbital junk.
- TRANSPONDER OPERATOR | Outer Belt Beacon Array Signal checks & hardware resets for long-range transit.

He didn't rush to submit. In a system like this, enthusiasm was just a fast track to getting screwed.

He knew how the maritime algorithms played the game. The second your status turned eligible, everyone slammed the submission button. Most of those permanent ship assignments sitting on the board were dead links—placeholders for positions that didn't exist. Then came the standard rejection, attached to a fallback offer: Position filled. However, an immediate opening exists for 90 days of manual ice-chipping on an unshielded surface ridge. Confirm within four hours. If you took it, you broke your back in a vacuum for pennies. If you refused, the system logged it as a "declined deployment" and dumped you straight to the back of the Belt-wide queue—position

#18,400. You'd be fifty before your name floated to the top again. Corporate elites and people with favors didn't even use this queue; they had direct routes. But when a real, legitimate berth actually opened up, the system was straightforward: if you were first in line, you were in.

Marek was patient because he had watched dozens of guys fall for that exact loop. Every few months, when a heavy haulage convoy rotated through or a bulk station decommission was authorized, a sudden labor deficit hit. When that happened, real berths flooded the board all at once, taking anyone with an active, un-trapped application.

The trick was knowing when the floodgates were about to open—and for that, you couldn't rely on official comms feeds. You had to go talk to people.

He pulled on his heavy canvas jacket and stepped out into the central conduit of Rivet-38.

Walking those familiar paths—the same ones he had explored as a curious child—was still strangely exciting. He preferred these routes, especially the ones he used to run through back when he lived to the limit, before he knew how low the actual ceiling was.

The station was nearly three hundred years old, and it smelled like it. But today, nostalgia wasn't enough. He had to fight his muscle memory and move. Either he acted, or he rotted. Most eligible workers chose to rot, eventually shipped off anyway as forced labor on whatever bottom-tier deals the bigger asteroids brokered.

He couldn't help it; his thoughts drifted to a few notorious individuals who had recently been expelled.

On an asteroid, there is a clear division. Some people are genuine troublemakers, and there is no helping them. But most are generations of people perfectly content to live in a dark, pressurized tin can: working twelve-hour shifts, gossiping about air rations, and dying in the same bunk they were born in.

He blamed their quiet obedience for his own situation. Disqualified on vague medical grounds, Marek felt penalized simply for existing outside the corporate elite. Yet everyone ignored the bigger picture to focus on daily routine. He hated their insular world, their family cliques guarding the comfortable indoor shifts, and the suspicious looks they gave anyone who didn't join them in the mess hall. But beneath the spite, there was a bitter thread of envy. He wished he could be like them—sitting in a plastic chair, drinking lukewarm chicory, and feeling like this damp tunnel was enough.

He walked past the main observation gallery. Through the thick glass window, he watched repair drones fixing the station's outer hull alongside three technicians in pristine, company-issued suits. They weren't locals. They were specialized contractors brought in from the inner stations for high-skill work. Corporations didn't trust asteroid dwellers with anything that mattered.

Even local maintenance jobs were an insult. Marek remembered a stint three years ago assigned to kitchen maintenance. He had spent two weeks trailing a repair drone just to service a broken dispenser. The machine barked simple instructions at him—turn a bolt, hand over a tool—while doing all the actual work itself. Marek was just a pair of thumbs with a heartbeat, hired solely to satisfy a human labor quota.

He turned down the narrow, dimly lit pipe-works of Sub-Level 2, heading toward the rear of the atmospheric scrubber plant.

If anyone knew when the next heavy convoy cycle was dropping, it was Coval.

Coval was fifty-eight, missing two fingers on his left hand from an old hydraulic accident, and ran pneumatic supply dispatch. He was one of the few people Marek could tolerate—mostly because Coval was just as cynical about the Belt, but had long since traded his frustration for home-brew and black-market station gossip.

Marek knocked on the heavy steel door. A muffled grunt came from inside, followed by the clatter of a wrench on a metal desk.

"It's open," Coval barked. "Unless you're from Environmental Safety, in which case the leak was already like that when I got here."

Marek pushed inside, slipping into the cramped, grease-scented office. "It's me, Coval."

Coval looked up, his bloodshot eyes narrowing through the haze of a vapor-cig. "The ghost of Sub-Level 4. I heard you hit forty-six today, Marek. Happy birthday. You're officially eligible to die in open space instead of rotting down here."

"I haven't submitted my deployment preferences yet," Marek said, sitting on an upturned filter crate. "I know how the queue works."

"Good. Then you're slightly less of an idiot than Miller from Sector 2," Coval snorted, spitting into a scrap bucket. "Kid turned forty-five last month, clicked 'apply' on the first Jupiter ice-hauler option he saw. Got rejected in ten days, turned down the surface-scrape counter-offer, and now he's sitting at position nineteen thousand. He'll be fifty-two before his name comes up again."

"That's why I'm here," Marek said, leaning forward. "What's coming through the sector? Real fleet stuff. Not corporate scrap duty."

Coval tapped his slate, glanced at the door to make sure it was latched, and leaned over his desk.

"You didn't hear it from me," Coval murmured. "Ceres Logistics is pulling three heavy ore freighters out of storage in six weeks. The navigation systems on those old haulers are outdated and unreliable, so regulation requires a five-man human crew on board for oversight—mechanics, riggers, and deck hands." Marek felt his chest tighten.

"Real berths?"

"Real berths," Coval confirmed. "Deep-run routes down to the Saturn rings. Long, ugly, quiet. But it's actual fleet time on a hull that moves. The corporate bulletin hasn't posted the manifest yet because they're still arguing over fuel credits with the Belt Authority. If you drop your application into the system the morning that manifest hits, you bypass the queue trap entirely."

"Six weeks," Marek said softly, calculating the days. "Six weeks sitting in a booth, stamping logs while everyone gossips about greenhouse rations."

"Six weeks is nothing," Coval said, pointing a grease-stained finger at Marek's chest. "You've waited forty-five years on this rock. Don't ruin it now by being impatient. You sit in your booth, you tap your green buttons, you nod at the idiots in the corridor, and you wait for my signal."

Marek walked the main ring with his hands in his pockets. The hall was crowded with shift-change traffic, people glued to their screens or arguing outside canteens.

The station was currently in a state of civil war over the "One-Pad" directive. The habitat board had proposed an amendment restricting lower-tier domestic units to a single networked terminal pad per household. To hear the locals tell it, you'd think the corporate board was coming to strangle their children. Marek had walked past Betty—a forty-year veteran of the desk—standing on a plastic crate outside the galley, red-faced, ranting to a crowd about "digital disenfranchisement." On the other side of the walkway, habitat loyalists shouted back, calling her a bandwidth hoarder.

Marek walked right past them, unnoticed. He felt only cold disgust. They lived inside a hollow rock floating in open space, yet they were ready to fight over who got a second screen in their bunk.

It was all so absurdly small. But then again, the whole system was built on absurdity.

Take the queue logic. Out of 19,000 names on the belt regional roster, maybe 300 actually wanted deep-space work, and maybe twenty were competent. Yet qualifications meant nothing. A veteran pilot at position #1,040 was routinely passed over for a novice who hit "SUBMIT" three milliseconds after a server refresh. The algorithm prioritized raw submission speed over skill simply because it was easier software-wise. Marek knew how to exploit the flaw using Coval's timestamp, but the fact that critical infrastructure ran on such a lazy design made his teeth ache.

The same artificiality governed his shifts. Twelve-hour workdays were a joke; human focus degraded after forty-five minutes of staring at diagnostic loops. Marek was sharp for half an hour before his brain went numb, tapping "VERIFY" on muscle memory. Inner-station systems injected fake errors to keep operators awake, but Rivet-38 didn't bother. For years, he hadn't seen a single discrepancy. He was decorative meat, legally required to sit in a chair so the company could claim a tax exemption.

Four-hour shifts with focused crews would make station life tolerable, but the twelve-hour block was an ancient labor relic nobody bothered to rewrite. So people sat for half a day doing nothing, then spent their off-days screaming in corridors over terminal quotas.

He thought about the history holos he skimmed as a kid. Seven hundred years ago, back on Earth, history had weight. Humans dropped atomic weapons, fought over continents, collapsed nations, and built desperate technologies to survive. It was brutal, but the stakes were real.

Now, humanity had reached the stars, bringing along safety lawyers, compliance software, and automated "Scotty" units. Space wasn't wild; it was an endlessly managed corporate holding pattern where humans were kept around like vestigial organs.

Then, a cold lump formed in his stomach.

He stared through the lead-glass port. Out there, past the blinking navigation lights of the docking bay, was the black—the six-week-away Ceres transit routes.

Existential dread hit him suddenly, paralyzing his knees.

For twenty-five years, Marek had built his identity around being the bitter outsider: the guy who hated Rivet-38, the guy too big for this rock, trapped by a medical flag and a corrupt system. His frustration had been his armor. It gave him a reason to wake up: I'm better than this place, and one day I'm getting out.

But Coval's leak was real. In six weeks, he was actually going to hit that button at the exact right millisecond. He was actually going to get a berth on a rusted ore-carrier bound for the Saturn outer ring.

And for the first time in his life, Marek was terrified.

What if he got out into the deep vacuum, sitting on an obsolete ship with four other washed-up fifty-year-olds, and realized the problem wasn't Rivet-38? What if the hollow, suffocating feeling wasn't the station air, but something inside his own chest?

He watched a cargo drone align itself with the lower airlock, its cold thrusters firing in silent bursts. He couldn't go back to the glass booth and be happy, but stepping forward felt like stepping off a cliff into total darkness.

Coval's original six-week estimate dragged into three agonizing months.

Corporate squabbling over fuel subsidies, legal battles with the Belt Authority, and orbital recalculations froze the rollout. For a quarter of a year, Marek lived in suspended animation, tapping green icons in Sub-Level 4, wondering if Coval had lied.

Now, less than twenty-four hours remained.

He was losing his mind. He couldn't sleep; his heart hammered against his ribs like a trapped bird. He couldn't eat; the synthetic protein paste tasted like wet chalk. His world had shrunk to a single numeric readout on his pad.

Worse than the waiting was the creeping paranoia. He spent three hours staring at the flickering light conduit above his door, terrified of a station-wide power outage. Power failures were exceedingly rare, but today he was convinced the primary reactor ring would collapse at 07:59:59. He wiped his palms every thirty seconds, convinced sweat would fail the terminal's thermal sensor.

All the impatience, resentment, and desperate longing he had suppressed for decades boiled to the surface. His hand trembled so violently he could barely hold his mug.

He sat cross-legged on his bunk, refreshing the corporate bulletin. Refresh. Refresh. Refresh.

It was useless. The drop was hard-coded for 08:00:00. But logic had broken down. Seconds stretched into hours.

07:58:12

..fear..

07:58:45

07:59:10

..fear..

Marek hovered his thumb three millimeters above the glass.

07:59:58

Aaaah.

07:59:59

The screen flashed. The blue banner dissolved into an amber notification:

CERES HEAVY FLEET RE-COMMISSION — AUXILIARY CREW MANIFEST OPEN
Muscle memory took over. Decades of tapping diagnostic buttons fired through his nervous system before his brain could process the words. Tap. Select: Hull Maintenance / Rigging. Confirm. Submit.

The screen froze for a heartbeat. Marek's throat locked.

Then, the interface shifted to flat grey:

[REGISTRATION RECEIVED] APPLICANT ID: 488-729-A DESIRED BERTH: CERES HEAVY AUXILIARY OVERSIGHT STATUS: PENDING QUEUE PROCESSING He sat frozen, chest heaving. He refreshed the page. PENDING.

Distrust washed over him. His personal pad was old—what if the mesh-network had dropped a packet? What if the ping hadn't registered at the central relay?

Unable to sit still, Marek bolted out of his bunk, threw open his door, and ran down the pipe-lined corridor to the main infrastructure junction. His boots clattered against the iron grating.

He slammed his hand against the heavy public kiosk on Ring 3, shoved his data key into the slot, and pulled up his profile.

The glass monitor hummed, displaying the master ledger line:

USER 488-729-A (MAREK) — APPLICATION RECEIVED TIMESTAMP: 08:00:00.104
STATUS: PENDING CENTRAL ALGORITHM PROCESSING IN PROGRESS It was real. His application was logged at 0.104 seconds after the drop. He had played the system as perfectly as humanly possible.

Marek leaned his forehead against the cold casing of the public terminal, closing his eyes. His body shook from the adrenaline crash, but there was no relief—only a vast, terrifying emptiness. The decision was entirely out of his hands, trapped inside an orbital server cluster where a script would decide his remaining years.

The system's response didn't take three weeks. It didn't take three days.

It came on a quiet Tuesday afternoon—a flat chime on his wall terminal while he sat staring at the floor.

[NOTIFICATION: APPLICATION STATUS UPDATE] APPLICANT ID: 488-729-A
BERTH: CERES HEAVY AUXILIARY OVERSIGHT RESULT: UNFULFILLED —
CANDIDATE SELECTION CONCLUDED REASON: QUALIFICATION PREFERENCE
MET BY ALTERNATE APPLICANTS When Marek read the lines, his legs simply gave out.

He didn't scream. He didn't punch the wall. He dropped straight onto the mattress, his chest collapsing. A wave of sickening weakness washed through him, draining the strength from his arms until he couldn't stop his hands from shaking.

Then came the boiling heat.

A dark rage erupted behind his eyes—a white-hot hatred directed at everything. He hated Coval for handing him a useless fairytale. He hated Betty and the idiots screaming about terminal pads. He hated the sleek corporate kids in pressure suits. He hated the station manager, the slag pit, the air scrubbers, and the rock under his boots.

For ten minutes, his mind spun reckless thoughts: I could open an airlock valve in Sub-Level 4. I could find Coval and break his jaw with a wrench. I could crawl into the unshielded exhaust conduit and let the thermal purge turn me to ash.

He had done everything right. He had waited forty-five years. He had tracked timestamps down to a tenth of a second and held his breath for six months.

And then, station chatter started filtering through the ventilation ducts.

The gossips outside were already talking about it. The Ceres berth wasn't a rumor; three crewed ore-carriers were pulling out of dry dock, and local names had been selected. But they weren't audit clerks or button-stampers. They were former fleet technicians—guys with flight hours, zero-g welding certifications, and decades of heavy rigging experience who had been waiting for a real ship. At least, that was the rumor—the station gossip—and Marek bought into it.

The realization hit Marek like a physical blow, knocking the rage right out of him and leaving behind hollow shame.

Of course.

How could he have been so blind? How could he have been so arrogantly stupid?

He had convinced himself that the solar system was run by a braindead algorithm that rewarded whoever hit a button first. He had comforted himself for decades with the bitter illusion that he was better than everyone else, trapped only by bad luck and a bad heart.

But when real spaceflight was on the line, the system wasn't stupid at all. It didn't want an old, broken clerk with calcified lungs. It wanted real spacefarers. It wanted competence.

He had lived under a rock his entire life, nursing a delusion of grandeur, completely blind to how useless he actually was. Humanity didn't conquer the stars by handing deep-space berths to desperate forty-six-year-old nobodies just because they survived forty-five years in a tin can.

The embarrassment was worse than the rejection. It shredded the last piece of armor he had left.

Marek pulled his knees to his chest and stared at the grey concrete wall. The light and noise in the universe seemed to drain away. The hum of the life-support pumps sounded like a funeral dirge.

When the shift alarm chimed for Sub-Level 4, he didn't move.

Let the terminal chime every eleven minutes. Let the slag bay burn. Let the supervisor fine him or revoke his rations. They had rejected him; now he rejected them.

He pulled his wool blanket over his head, burying himself in the dark, begging his brain to shut off, slipping into the numb, grey quiet.

Betty's hands were shaking against the cracked plastic frame of her console.

She sat in the cramped cubicle of Environmental & Resource Logistics, surrounded by the dull gurgle of grey-water recyclers running behind the bulkhead. She was supposed to be cross-referencing filtration throughput, but she couldn't focus.

Her blood was boiling, every nerve inflamed by the memory of Derek.

Derek was the station's "community cohesion" liaison—a sleek bastard with perfect teeth, clear skin, and an infuriating habit of leaning over her desk like he owned the place. Just two hours ago, in front of four junior clerks, Derek had dropped another backhanded jab.

"Still clutching your ancient paper-slates, Betty?" he had said, flashing that smooth smile. "If you spent less time yelling about household terminal limits on plastic crates and a little more time thinking about the broader asteroid ecosystem, maybe Sub-Level 2 wouldn't be three days behind on filter cycles. You're just so delightfully set in your ways, isn't that right?"

She hated him with an intensity that made her ears ring.

Who was he to talk about community? He was a stingy corporate politician who didn't give a damn about Rivet-38; he just cared about looking good for his annual review so he could transfer to a luxury dome on Mars. He called her close-minded, slow, selfish—just because she refused to let him quietly strip away another piece of local dignity under the banner of "station optimization."

"I've spent forty years at this desk, you arrogant little snake," she muttered, stabbing a finger into the keyboard. "Forty years keeping your air clean and your water drinkable while you polish your shoes."

Her mind kept replaying the scene, looping his smug face, his condescending tone, his endless lectures. She couldn't eat, she couldn't focus on her logs, and every time she tried to read a routine report, Derek's voice echoed in her head.

Then, her terminal screen gave a strange, metallic click.

Betty froze. The standard blue diagnostic stream flickered. In the center of her interface, a thick, yellow error border locked around an automated processing ticket.

She blinked, wiping her eyes. She looked at it once. Then a second time. Then a third.

In forty years of sitting at the desk, Betty had never seen an unprompted system error. The automated algorithms were supposed to be seamless and cold. The human staff were just decorative thumbs legally required to sit in chairs to satisfy the 25% quota. The machine made the choices; the human clicked "confirm." That was the rule.

But sitting right there on her monitor was a blatant, undeniable system logic glitch.

The central server had glitched during a routine update. An automated rejection had misfired, trapping the algorithm in an error loop it couldn't resolve on its own. The

machine had made a mistake, stuck trying to enforce a bad command.

It was a real mistake. A genuine, mechanical blind spot.

For a second, Betty just stared at it. The system wasn't infallible. The great corporate algorithm had actually stumbled.

Her forty years of deep muscle memory took over. Without consciously thinking, Betty reached across her desk and flipped open the dust cover over the physical manual override interface—a thick, yellow button that hadn't been pressed in decades.

She slammed her palm down on the manual override switch, breaking the error loop. She typed in the correction, cleared the bad code, and hit the heavy green confirmation button.

[OVERRIDE EXECUTED] RECORD CORRECTED & SYNCHRONIZED

The terminal gave a sharp chime. The yellow error border vanished. The system accepted her override, quietly updated the master ledger, and cleared the ticket from her queue.

The screen returned to its usual blue stream.

Betty sat back in her squeaky chair, heart thumping. The entire action had taken less than ten seconds. It was an invisible blip in the station's endless stream of data, but for a single moment, a human hand had corrected the machine.

She stared at the calm blue monitor for a long minute. The rush of adrenaline faded, leaving her alone with the hum of the water pipes.

Then, her chest tightened, her brows furrowed, and her mind snapped right back to Derek's condescending face.

"Slow," she thought bitterly, her fingers curling into fists again as she glared at the empty corridor outside her cubicle. "He called me slow..."

A sharp, insistent chime cut through the dark of the cubicle, jerking Marek out of his heavy sleep.

He forced himself upright, his head spinning as he squinted at the wall monitor. The cold rejection notice was gone. In its place, a high-priority system line flashed in bright, unyielding green:

[MANUAL OVERRIDE LOGGED — STATUS: ACCEPTED] BERTH ASSIGNED: CERES
HEAVY ORE-CARRIER (DEEP-RUN AUXILIARY) REPORT TO DOCKING BAY 3

WITHIN 48 HOURS.

Marek stood frozen in his cramped bunk room. His mind went completely blank, his eyes locked on the text, staring at an impossible reality.